

01 CHALLENGE

The Negotiator — Study Abroad Edition

Voice agents that call consultancies and universities, compare real study-abroad budgets, and negotiate — so no student ever overpays for their future again

POWERED BY ElevenLabs (The AI Audio and Voice Agents Platform)

Hack-Nation 6th Global AI Hackathon · Adapted Vertical: Study-Abroad Consultancy (Pakistan → UK)

Goals and Motivation

Meet Ali

Ali is 19. He has just completed his Intermediate (FSc) in Faisalabad, Pakistan, and he wants to study LLB in the UK. He is sitting with his father on a Sunday evening, phone in hand, with one question that will shape the next four years of his family's finances: “What is the real budget?”

The market knows quite a lot about what this journey should cost. But when Ali calls study-abroad consultancies, every firm gives him a different number. One quotes a total first-year budget of around PKR 4.5 million; another quotes over PKR 9 million — for the same degree, the same country, the same student. The single biggest and most variable chunk is the Initial Deposit (the tuition-fee deposit a UK university requires before issuing the CAS visa document). For Pakistani students, real published deposits range from £2,000 at Queen Mary University of London, to £6,000 at the University of Manchester, to £8,500 at UWE Bristol, to £10,000 at the University of Hull — a 5x spread, and each consultancy quotes only the universities it is affiliated with.

Why the difference? Consultancies earn commission from partner universities. So the “budget” Ali receives is not the market price — it is the price of the universities that pay that consultancy the best commission. Almost nobody calls 5–8 consultancies, describes the same academic profile identically each time, extracts an itemised budget (tuition, deposit, service fee, IELTS, visa fee, bank statement requirement, living costs), and compares. It takes days, and the fee structures are deliberately hard to compare.

So Ali does what most students do: he visits two consultancies, trusts the friendlier counsellor, pays a non-refundable deposit — and hopes. If the choice was wrong, the deposit is gone: UK tuition deposits are non-refundable in most cases. The price in the seminar is not the price at the visa stage.

That gap — between the budget Ali will pay and the budget he could have paid — is what this challenge asks you to close. For the first time, software can literally pick up the phone and call every consultancy in the city.

Current Challenges

Every phone-priced market shows the same pattern; study-abroad consulting in Pakistan is a textbook case. Hundreds of thousands of Pakistani students go abroad every year, served by thousands of small consultancy firms — phone-and-WhatsApp operations, not tech businesses with transparent online pricing. The same three failures repeat:

OPAQUE PRICING	Total first-year budgets quoted for the same student and the same degree can differ by 2x or more between firms. Initial deposits alone range from £2,000 to £10,000 depending on which affiliated university the consultancy pushes. The only sanity check is gathering multiple quotes — and there is no efficient way to do it today.
BIASED ESTIMATES	Consultancy quotes are commission-driven, not student-driven. A firm quotes the universities that pay it best, hides or minimises service fees (“free counselling” that is recovered elsewhere), and reveals extra charges — courier, embassy, “file processing”, forced insurance — only after the student is committed. Lowball-then-upcharge is a business model, not an accident.
NO WAY TO SHOP AROUND	The market is thousands of small firms reachable one phone call at a time. Students routinely report losing non-refundable deposits and paying surprise fees — yet almost nobody has the days required to call 5–8 consultancies with an identical profile and compare itemised budgets properly.

Your Challenge

Build THE NEGOTIATOR (Study Abroad Edition) — a working end-to-end MVP of a voice-agent system that, for a student with a defined academic profile, gathers real study-abroad budgets by phone from consultancies (and, where possible, university international offices), reports them in comparable itemised form, and negotiates the best total package.

Whatever the destination country, the system always has the same three beats. **First, intake:** build a complete, structured student profile — through a voice interview, through documents the student already has (transcripts, IELTS/PTE score, bank statements, existing consultancy quotes), or both. **Second, the calls:** your agent phones the market — real consultancies, humans role-playing counsellors, or counter-agents you build — describes the student profile identically every time, and extracts itemised budget quotes. **Third, the close:** it negotiates — leveraging one consultancy's offer against another, questioning service fees and forced add-ons, flagging suspicious outliers — and reports back with a ranked, evidence-backed comparison: call recordings, transcripts, and a recommended pathway explained in plain language.

Conversation design is as much part of the challenge as the technology. How your agent handles a pushy counsellor, a “come to the office and we will discuss”, or a hard sell for one specific partner university determines whether it comes back with a usable itemised budget or a useless range.

A negotiator — not a quote form

Your solution must conduct real voice conversations, not fill web forms or scrape aggregators. The other end of the line is flexible: let the agent call real consultancies about a real student profile; answer the calls yourself, playing different counsellor types — the commission-driven pusher, the fee-hider, the honest-but-vague one; or build counterparty agents and run agent-to-agent. All are fine, as long as you can simulate several distinct negotiation types and the quoted budget moves during the call because of what your agent knows and says.

Vertical-specific parameters (profile taxonomy, deposit benchmarks per university, red-flag rules, negotiation levers) should be configuration, not code: switching your system from UK-LLB consultancies to Australia-nursing consultancies — or back to the original movers vertical — should mean swapping a config file, not rewriting your agents.

Build all three of these modules

01 The Estimator — Intake by Interview or Documents

An intake agent builds a complete, structured student profile — the thing that makes a later quote binding rather than bait. Two intake paths, and strong submissions offer both: a voice interview that asks what a professional education counsellor would ask (last qualification, grades/CGPA, English test status, target degree and country, budget ceiling, sponsor and bank statement capacity, intake season), and document intake — transcripts, IELTS report, bank statements, existing quotes from other firms — parsed into the same structured spec. The student confirms the profile before any calls are made. This is the direct attack on the biased-estimate problem: incomplete profiles are exactly what lets consultancies quote whatever suits their commission.

Required: Intake must offer a voice interview built on ElevenLabs Agents plus at least one document type; both paths must produce the same structured student profile (e.g. JSON), confirmed by the user and reused verbatim across every call.

02 The Caller — Parallel Quote Gathering

Your agent phones the market. Three setups are all valid: (1) real calls — point the agent at a real student profile and let it phone real consultancies via Twilio/SIP; (2) human-in-the-loop — answer the calls yourself, playing distinct counsellor types: the commission pusher who only quotes high-deposit partner universities, the fee-hider who says “counselling is free”, the stonewaller who insists on an office visit; (3) simulated market — build counterparty counsellor-agents with different commission structures and run agent-to-agent. Whatever the setup, the caller must describe the student identically, handle friction (interruptions, “bring your documents to the office”, evasive answers), and extract an itemised, comparable quote from each call: tuition per year, initial deposit, consultancy service fee, application/embassy/courier fees, IELTS/medical costs, required bank statement, and living costs. Show where the call list would come from in the real world (e.g. Google Places data for education consultants in Lahore, Faisalabad, and Islamabad).

Required: Any counterparty setup is allowed, but your demo must show live calls against at least three distinct negotiation styles, every quote captured in structured, comparable form with all fees itemised.

03 The Closer — Negotiation & Reporting

With quotes in hand, your agent negotiates: it leverages competing offers (“Another firm is offering the same LLB pathway with a £2,000 deposit university and zero service fee — can you match it?”), pushes on service fees and forced add-ons, asks for scholarship or instalment options on the deposit, and applies red-flag rules — a total budget far below market usually hides fees or a low-quality institution; a deposit far above the university's published figure means padding. Then it reports: a ranked comparison the student's family can trust, with a recommended pathway, full transcripts and recordings, itemised fee breakdowns in both GBP and PKR, and a plain-language explanation of why.

Required: At least one demonstrated negotiation in which the price or terms change during the call because of leverage your agent gathered; the final report must rank all quotes and cite transcript evidence.

The Conversation Requirement

Voice is the mechanism of trust on both ends of the call — and in this market the counterparty is a professional persuader. Your prototype must address the following explicitly:

- **Who is the agent speaking for?** Does it disclose that it is an AI calling on behalf of a student and their family? How does it respond to “am I talking to a robot?” — gracefully, honestly, and without losing the quote?
- **How does it survive friction?** Counsellors deflect (“visit our office”), upsell (“only our partner university guarantees the visa”), and multitask. Latency, barge-in handling, and turn-taking decide whether the call sounds like a serious client or a bot.
- **Where does the honesty line sit?** The agent may use competing quotes as leverage — but it must never invent grades, fake an IELTS score, misrepresent the sponsor's bank statement, or fabricate a competing offer. Show how you constrain it.

- **How does every call end?** With a structured outcome: an itemised budget quote, a callback commitment, or a documented decline — never a vague “they said around 50 lakh”.

Play the calls in your demo and highlight how you addressed these four points.

Data Sources and Hints

VOICE AGENTS & TELEPHONY	ElevenLabs Agents Platform for the conversational agents (system prompts, tools, knowledge bases, agent transfer, human handoff). Batch Calling / Twilio & SIP for parallel outbound calls. Agent Tools & MCP to log structured quotes mid-call and write results into your comparison backend.
MARKET DISCOVERY	Google Places / OSM: education consultants by city (Lahore, Faisalabad, Islamabad, Karachi) with phone numbers, ratings, and review volume — your call list, built programmatically.
PRICE BENCHMARKS	Ground truth for red-flag detection: official UK university fee and deposit pages (e.g. QMUL £2,000; Manchester £6,000 for Pakistan-domiciled applicants; UWE Bristol £8,500; Hull £10,000), UKVI maintenance-funds requirements, UCAS course fees, and British Council guidance. A deposit quoted above the published figure is a red flag by definition.
DOCUMENT PARSING	Turn what the student already has — transcripts, IELTS TRF, bank statements, existing consultancy quotations — into the structured student profile, using vision models or OCR. Same schema as the interview output.
THE OTHER END OF THE LINE	Three valid setups, any mix: real calls to real consultancies; yourself role-playing distinct counsellor types (commission pusher, fee-hider, office-visit stonewaller); or built counter-agents with different commission strategies. Record golden calls and build simple evals: does the agent extract every fee? Does it catch a padded deposit?

What Makes a Strong Submission

Strong Submissions...	Weak Submissions...
Show a real negotiation: a service fee waived, a lower-deposit university surfaced, or an instalment plan secured during a live call because of leverage the agent gathered.	Stage a screenplay: two agents reading pre-written dialogue at each other is a demo of text-to-speech, not of negotiation.
Pick a provable pain: show the spread with real numbers — published UK deposits for Pakistani students already range £2,000–£10,000 — then make quotes comparable: same student, same degree, itemised fees.	Collect quotes that aren't comparable and hide the differences in a polished dashboard.
Close the loop: intake → calls → negotiation → ranked recommendation with transcript evidence.	Over-engineer the agent stack and under-engineer the conversations. This challenge is won in call design, not model architecture.
Be honest about the hard parts: AI disclosure, honesty constraints (never fake grades or bids), and failure modes handled gracefully.	Let the agent bluff: an invented IELTS score or fake competing offer may win the demo — and lose the student's visa, and the market, forever.

Success Criteria

A submission fully meets this challenge when:

- **The loop is closed.** A single vertical (e.g. Pakistan → UK LLB) runs end to end: intake → calls → negotiation → ranked recommendation with transcript evidence.
- **One structured student profile**, built by voice interview and at least one document type, is confirmed by the user and reused verbatim across every call.
- **Live calls are demonstrated** against at least three distinct counsellor negotiation styles; every quote is captured in structured, comparable form with fees itemised.
- **At least one negotiation** shows the price or terms measurably change during the call because of leverage the agent gathered — not because the script said so.
- **AI disclosure and honesty constraints hold:** the agent never invents grades, scores, funds, or a fake competing offer; discloses it is an AI when asked; and handles friction gracefully.
- **Every call ends in a structured outcome** — an itemised budget quote, a callback commitment, or a documented decline.
- **The final report ranks all quotes**, cites recordings and transcripts, shows totals in GBP and PKR, and explains the recommended pathway in plain language.

Why This Matters

The consumer harm is documented, not hypothetical: UK tuition deposits are non-refundable in most cases, so a wrong consultancy-driven choice can cost a Pakistani family £2,000–£10,000 outright — often a year of household income. Deposits for Pakistani applicants specifically have been raised by many UK universities, making the stakes higher for exactly this market. Hidden service fees, forced add-ons, and commission-biased university recommendations are standard practice, and families have no benchmark to push back with.

For ElevenLabs, this is the thesis in miniature: a market of thousands of small consultancy operators who will never adopt transparent quoting software — but every one of them answers the phone. A voice agent is the first technology that meets this market where it is, with no integration required on the other end. And study-abroad is only the beachhead: the same system generalises to Hajj/Umrah packages, wedding vendors, private hospitals, and car purchase — every Pakistani market where the real price is only available by phone, to whoever has the patience to ask for it.